

The Reality of Meaning — Summary, Connections, and Critique

Question: Can you summarize the Reality of *.md, relate the concepts to the rest of the repo, and critique the logic of the argument?

The Argument in Brief

Seven compressed points that take the semiotic triad — affording, specifying, satisfying — and promote it from a framework for *describing cognition* into a claim about *what exists*. The spine: reality is made of relations rather than substances (Peirce, Rovelli); only stable relations endure; natural selection is just stability criteria operating at the ecological level; and within any triad, satisfying holds privileged status because it specifies the criteria for existence itself. Affording is the energy coupling (forward loop, acting), specifying is the information coupling (feedback loop, perceiving), and together they close the loop through which energy gets directed toward stability. Satisfying, though — the term that decides everything — has no box in the diagram.

Where It Sits in the Repo

This is the whole thoughtline compressed onto one page: Peirce's triad, the Chapter 33 figure's three terms, Rasmussen's hierarchy with purpose on top, control theory's forward and feedback loops, stability as the survival criterion, and the internal-versus-external purpose distinction from `Three classes of systems.md`. Three connections are worth calling out specifically.

Point 7 answers a question Flach raised but left open. In *What Matters?* Chapter 12 he observes that the cost function "is not represented in the block diagram" and speculates that this omission is why value dropped out of information-processing psychology. Point 7 states it as structure rather than accident: satisfying is implicit, there is no box for it. That is a real explanation for a historical failure, and it has teeth.

Point 5 is Pirsig in CSE vocabulary. "Satisfying determines the 'goodness' or 'fitness' of a thing," sitting at the top because it specifies why one thing exists and another goes extinct — that is the Metaphysics of Quality, with Quality prior to and determinative of what exists rather than a property added to things already there. What `Pirsig_MOQ.md` argues philosophically, this states mechanically.

Rovelli is new here, and he is the strongest addition. Relational quantum mechanics gives the anti-substance claim a footing in fundamental physics that Pirsig's Quality and Rayner's Natural Inclusion never had. He is also the missing bridge to Matthew Smith's essay — Rovelli explicitly grounds his relationalism in Nāgārjuna's emptiness in *Helgoland*, which is exactly where Smith started. And points 2 and 3 are Smith's argument reached independently: both subordinate Darwinian selection to a more general persistence criterion, Smith via thermodynamics, this via control-theoretic stability.

Critique

Read as working notes the compression is fine, but several joints need load-bearing work before this holds as an argument.

1. "Stable" needs a definition independent of "endures," or points 2, 3 and 5 form a closed circle. As written, stability is glossed as "when a triad becomes unstable it goes out of existence" — which means stable things are the ones that last, and the ones that last are the stable ones. The claim has the grammar of an empirical proposition while possibly doing no work. This matters most at point 3: if stability is tautological, "natural selection is just a description of the stability criteria" reduces to "selection describes what survives," which is the survival-of-the-survivors circularity biologists escape only by defining fitness *in advance* as expected reproductive output. The fix is available in Flach's own Chapter 7: control theory defines stability precisely — bounded response to bounded disturbance, with gain and phase margins — but that requires naming the state variables and the perturbations. Borrowing the word without the machinery gets the rigor by association.

2. Point 5 equivocates between constitutive and selective criteria. "Criteria for existence" can mean what makes something count as a thing at all, or what determines which things persist. These differ. A tornado that dissipates in ten minutes *existed*; an extinct species *existed*. Failing the persistence test does not retroactively unmake something, it makes it past. If only the weak reading is meant, then satisfying specifies criteria for *persistence*, not existence — a lesser claim, and not obviously enough to earn the top of the Abstraction Hierarchy. If the strong reading is meant, it is a genuinely radical thesis and the "because" in point 5 is carrying it without argument. Note that Rasmussen's original justification is explanatory priority within a description of a work domain; converting that into existential priority in reality is the leap the whole document rests on, and it is the one sentence that gets no support.

3. "Just" is doing too much in point 3. Natural selection has machinery stability alone does not supply: heritable variation and differential reproduction, which is what makes it *cumulative* rather than merely conservative. Tornadoes are stable-ish and leave no descendants; lineages accumulate design across generations. Smith's essay actually handles this better — he keeps the distinction, arguing Darwinian selection is thermodynamic dissipation that *acquired* the ability to copy its blueprint. Also, "at the level of ecologies" asserts a position in the levels-of-selection debate (gene, organism, group, species) as though it were definitional.

4. Point 7's two options do not cover point 2's own examples. Satisfying criteria are said to be either internal (self-organizing, conditions for survival) or external (set by a designer). But point 2 explicitly includes tornadoes, and a tornado has neither — no intrinsic purpose to persist, no designer. Dissipative structures fall straight through the gap, which is also where the repo's own three-class taxonomy gets flattened into two. Either a third category is needed, or satisfying gets stretched to cover efficiency-of-dissipation — and that weakens it badly, because efficiency is a *consequence* of the physics, not a criterion anything is oriented toward. That is precisely Smith's magnetic-field-versus-heart distinction, and it cuts here too. Relatedly, for designed artifacts the external criterion determines whether the thing is *good*, not whether it *is* — a badly-set thermostat still exists — so point 7's second clause only works under the weak reading of point 5.

5. Peirce and Rovelli are both relational but not in the same arity. Peirce's triad is irreducibly three-termed — the interpretant is what stops it collapsing into a pair of dyads. Rovelli's relationality holds between *any two* physical systems; a property is definite relative to one other system, and no third term is required. So "relations (triads)" quietly attributes the same structure to both. This is worth pinning down, because triadicity is exactly what earns satisfying a seat. If the ontology only forces dyads, you get affording and specifying — energy coupling and information coupling — and the third term has to be argued for rather than inherited.

What Is Strongest

Point 6 is the best thing here and, as far as I can tell, just right: parsing the closed loop into energy coupling forward and information coupling back explains *why* the triad has the shape it does instead of asserting it, and it maps cleanly onto control theory without strain. Point 7's no-box observation is a genuine insight. And the overall ambition is the correct next move — if Chapter 33 is serious about metaphysical foundations, this is what taking it seriously looks like. The argument mostly needs its connective tissue restored, and the single highest-leverage repair is giving "stability" a definition that does not presuppose the conclusion.